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STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Created in God's Image

Grades 5–8 · Religion

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Theological frame: The Hebrew concept of *imago Dei* carries within it not only dignity but vocation — to be made in God's image is to be called to create, to love, and to seek justice. The Harlem Renaissance can be read as a prophetic movement: artists, writers, and musicians declaring what God had already declared about Black humanity, against a society that refused to listen.

01

PART 1

Scripture and theological analysis: the prophetic voice

Read: Amos 5:21–24 (God rejects empty worship and demands justice) and Matthew 25:31–46 (what you do to the least, you do to God).

1. How do these passages together establish not just that dignity must be affirmed — but that failing to affirm it is a sin? What does this mean for bystanders, not just perpetrators?

02

PART 2

The Harlem Renaissance as prophetic witness

The biblical prophets spoke out when society violated the dignity of the poor and marginalized. They did not simply describe injustice — they insisted on a different reality in God's name.

2. In what sense were the Harlem Renaissance artists, writers, and musicians acting as prophetic witnesses? Use at least two specific examples (a poem, a painting, a song) to support your argument:

PART 3

03 Can art be prayer?

The Catholic tradition has always understood art as a form of prayer — Michelangelo's Sistine Chapel ceiling, Gregorian chant, the stained glass of Chartres. These are not mere decoration; they are theological statements made visible or audible.

3. Argue: is Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* a form of prayer or prophetic witness? What theological claim does it make, and how does its formal language (silhouette, light, circle) carry that claim?

PART 4

04 Your theological reflection

CST Principle 1 says human dignity is not earned — it is given by God and cannot be taken away. But structurally, it can be denied.

Write a theological reflection (5–6 sentences): **what is the difference between dignity being present and dignity being acknowledged? And what does this distinction require of us?**

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Choose one artwork in the exhibition and write a one-paragraph theological reflection: what does this work say about the nature of the human person? Does it affirm *imago Dei*? How? Would you call it sacred art? Why or why not?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

CLOSING PRAYER

God of justice and beauty, you made us in your image — every one of us. May we have the courage of the prophets and the artists of Harlem: to insist on that truth, to make it visible, and to refuse the lie that any person is worth less than another. Amen.